UNIT 5 · TOPIC 5.6

Detecting Attacks on Data and Applications

Assignment

Instructions: 15 practice questions + 3 coding assignment(s), 30 points total. Show your work for short-answer items. Coding assignments may be completed here or in the interactive auto-graded environment on the course site (same problem, same points).

Name: **Date:** **Class:**

Practice Questions

5.6.a · Application monitoring and logging

1. A single failed login for one user is unremarkable. Fifty failed logins from one IP across twenty usernames in two minutes is a signal. What does this illustrate? (1 pt)

- ○ A. The pattern, not the individual event, is the signal
- ○ B. Failed logins should never be logged because they are too common
- ○ C. Alerts should fire on every single failed login
- ○ D. Only successful logins indicate an attack

2. Select ALL fields a well-designed security log line typically includes. (3 pts)

- □ A. Timestamp
- □ B. Requesting IP address
- □ C. Result/status code
- □ D. The victim's home address

(Select ALL that apply.)

3. What is a SIEM? (1 pt)

- ○ A. A firewall that inspects application traffic
- ○ B. A tool that scans source code for vulnerabilities
- ○ C. An endpoint agent that blocks malware on laptops
- ○ D. A platform that centralizes logs from many sources and applies detection rules to raise alerts

4. Name the log severity level at which security-relevant events (like authentication attempts) should be recorded so they are not silently dropped in production. (1 pt)

5. Why do defenders stream logs to a remote aggregator in real time rather than only storing them locally on the application server? (1 pt)

- ○ A. Remote storage compresses logs so more history can be kept
- ○ B. An attacker who compromises the server can delete local logs to cover their tracks; a remote copy preserves the forensic record
- ○ C. Local logs cannot include timestamps

○ D. Remote aggregators automatically block attackers

5.6.b · Data loss detection (DLP)

6. Which DLP detection strategy inspects the actual data leaving the organization for patterns like credit-card numbers or SSNs? (1 pt)

○ A. Volume/behavior-based detection

○ B. Endpoint detection and response

○ C. Content-based detection

○ D. Least privilege

7. Select ALL statements that correctly describe volume/behavior-based DLP detection. (3 pts)

□ A. It can catch exfiltration of encrypted or compressed data that has no recognizable content pattern

□ B. It relies on comparing an account's current activity against its normal baseline

□ C. It requires reading and understanding the literal content of every file transferred

□ D. A sudden large transfer to an unfamiliar destination is a classic signal it looks for

(Select ALL that apply.)

8. Why do effective DLP programs maintain an approved-destination allowlist? (1 pt)

○ A. Allowlisted destinations do not need to be monitored at all

○ B. Allowlists stop attackers from using approved destinations

○ C. So legitimate large transfers (backups, sanctioned partners) don't drown out real alerts with false positives

○ D. Allowlists encrypt the data sent to those destinations

9. Name the DLP deployment point that runs on individual laptops/workstations and can block a USB copy of a flagged file, which network DLP alone would never see. (1 pt)

10. How does DLP differ from a purely forensic control like log review? (1 pt)

○ A. DLP only reviews data after it has been stored in logs

○ B. DLP can only see data on servers, not on laptops

○ C. DLP replaces log review, so logs are no longer needed

○ D. A well-integrated DLP system can act preventively in real time, blocking or quarantining a transfer before it completes

5.6.c · Digital evidence analysis and attack classification

11. A single failed-login spike is observed. What is the analyst's correct next step before declaring it a brute-force attack? (1 pt)

○ A. Check the underlying evidence, e.g. is it one source targeting many usernames, or many sources targeting one username?

○ B. Block the source IP immediately and close the case

○ C. Reset every user's password as a precaution

○ D. Wait for a second spike before doing anything

12. Select ALL statements that correctly describe an indicator of compromise (IOC). (3 pts)

- □ A. A single IOC is rarely conclusive proof of a specific attack type by itself
- □ B. Examples include a suspicious IP, a known-malware file hash, or a credential-harvesting URL
- □ C. Attack classification typically requires reasoning about multiple IOCs together
- □ D. An IOC always proves the attacker's exact identity

(Select ALL that apply.)

13. Why does chain of custody matter for evidence even outside a courtroom? (1 pt)

- ○ A. Chain of custody is only needed when police are involved
- ○ B. It makes evidence files smaller and easier to store
- ○ C. It replaces the need to keep original copies
- ○ D. An internal investigation's credibility also depends on being able to show evidence wasn't tampered with

14. Name the widely-used framework that gives analysts a shared vocabulary for attack techniques so classifications are consistent across teams. (1 pt)

15. An evidence bundle contains a known-malware file hash AND a suspicious email attachment. Which best describes correct classification reasoning? (1 pt)

- ○ A. Classify it as malware, since a file hash is stronger evidence than an email
- ○ B. Score how many known indicators support each category and communicate which is best-supported, noting remaining uncertainty if any
- ○ C. Classify it as phishing, since the attachment arrived first
- ○ D. Report both categories equally and let management decide

Coding Assignments (Python 3)

5.6.a · Application monitoring and logging

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem 5.6.a: Brute-force detector (SIEM alert rule)

Skill: Detect Attacks · **Maps to:** 5.6.A · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Implement the SIEM alert rule described in the lesson: given a list of parsed application log entries, return every IP address whose failed-login (`401`) count exceeds a threshold within a rolling time window, a classic brute-force signal.

Function contract

Implement `solve(entries: list, threshold: int, window_seconds: int) -> list` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

- `entries`: `list[dict]`, each `{"ip": str, "ts": int, "status": int}` (`ts` = seconds since start of log, not necessarily sorted).
- `threshold`: `int`, minimum number of `401` events within the window to flag the IP.

- `window_seconds`: `int`, rolling window size, in seconds (inclusive on both ends).

Output

A **sorted, de-duplicated** `list[str]` of flagged IP addresses.

Examples

```
entries = [
  {"ip":"10.0.0.1","ts":0,"status":401},
  {"ip":"10.0.0.1","ts":10,"status":401},
  {"ip":"10.0.0.1","ts":20,"status":401},
]
solve(entries, threshold=3, window_seconds=60) -> ["10.0.0.1"]
```

```
entries = [{"ip":"10.0.0.2","ts":0,"status":200}]
solve(entries, threshold=1, window_seconds=60) -> []   # success responses never count
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- Only `status == 401` entries count toward the brute-force count; other codes are ignored.
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Starter code:

```
"""Starter code for 5.6.a. Student completes the TODO.
This file intentionally FAILS the tests until implemented."""
from typing import Dict, List


def solve(entries: List[Dict[str, object]], threshold: int, window_seconds: int) -> List[str]:
    """Flag source IPs whose failed-login (401) count reaches >= threshold within some
    rolling window of window_seconds — the brute-force SIEM rule from the lesson.

    Args:
        entries: list of {"ip": str, "ts": int, "status": int} log entries. `ts` is seconds
            since the start of the log; `status` is an HTTP status code.
        threshold: minimum number of 401s within the window to flag the IP.
        window_seconds: inclusive rolling window size, in seconds.
    Returns:
        sorted, de-duplicated list[str] of flagged IP addresses.
    """
    # TODO: implement per prompt.md
    raise NotImplementedError("implement solve() — see prompt.md")
```

5.6.b · Data loss detection (DLP)

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem 5.6.b: DLP egress rule

Skill: Detect Attacks · **Maps to:** 5.6.B · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Implement the volume/behavior-based DLP rule described in the lesson: given a list of outbound transfer events, flag the ones that exceed a size threshold AND go to a destination that is not on the organization's approved-destination list, a classic egress-monitoring rule.

Function contract

Implement `solve(transfers: list, approved_destinations: list, volume_threshold_mb: int) -> list` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

- `transfers`: `list[dict]`, each `{"id": str, "bytes_mb": int, "destination": str}`.
- `approved_destinations`: `list[str]` of known-good destination names.
- `volume_threshold_mb`: `int`, transfer must exceed this size to be eligible for flagging.

Output

Sorted `list[str]` of flagged transfer ids.

Examples

```
transfers = [{"id":"t1","bytes_mb":500,"destination":"unknown-cloud.example"}]
solve(transfers, ["corp-backup.internal"], volume_threshold_mb=100) -> ["t1"]
```

```
transfers = [{"id":"t2","bytes_mb":500,"destination":"corp-backup.internal"}]
solve(transfers, ["corp-backup.internal"], volume_threshold_mb=100) -> []   # approved destination
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- The size comparison is strict (`bytes_mb > volume_threshold_mb`).
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Starter code:

```
"""Starter code for 5.6.b. Student completes the TODO.
This file intentionally FAILS the tests until implemented."""
from typing import Dict, List


def solve(
    transfers: List[Dict[str, object]],
    approved_destinations: List[str],
    volume_threshold_mb: int,
) -> List[str]:
    """DLP egress rule: flag outbound transfers that exceed a volume threshold AND go to a
    destination that is not on the approved list.

    Args:
        transfers: list of {"id": str, "bytes_mb": int, "destination": str}.
        approved_destinations: list[str] of known-good destination names.
        volume_threshold_mb: int — a transfer must exceed this size (strictly greater than)
```

```
        to be eligible for flagging.
    Returns:
        sorted list[str] of the transfer `id`s that should be flagged.
    """
    # TODO: implement per prompt.md
    raise NotImplementedError("implement solve() — see prompt.md")
```

5.6.c · Digital evidence analysis and attack classification

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem 5.6.c: Attack classifier (evidence -> category)

Skill: Detect Attacks, Collaborate · **Maps to:** 5.6.B, 5.6.C · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Formalize the analyst reasoning process from the lesson: given a bundle of evidence indicators collected during an investigation, score each known attack category by how many of its indicators are present, and return the best-supported classification.

Function contract

Implement `solve(indicators: list) -> str` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

`indicators`: `list[str]` of evidence tags (may contain duplicates).

Known indicator-to-category mapping

- `"brute-force"`: `multiple_401_responses`, `single_source_ip`, `many_usernames_targeted`, `credential_guessing_pattern`
- `"sql-injection"`: `sql_meta_characters_in_request`, `database_error_in_response`, `union_select_pattern`, `unexpected_query_result_size`
- `"malware"`: `known_malware_file_hash`, `unexpected_process_spawned`, `outbound_c2_connection`, `persistence_mechanism_installed`
- `"phishing"`: `suspicious_email_attachment`, `credential_harvesting_url`, `spoofed_sender_domain`, `user_reported_suspicious_email`

Output

`str`, the category with the most matching indicators (as a set; duplicates don't add extra weight). Ties go to the alphabetically first tied category. `"unknown"` if nothing matches.

Examples

```
["multiple_401_responses", "single_source_ip"]  ->  "brute-force"
["server_restarted"]                             ->  "unknown"
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Starter code:

```
"""Starter code for 5.6.c. Student completes the TODO.
This file intentionally FAILS the tests until implemented."""
from typing import List


def solve(indicators: List[str]) -> str:
    """Classify an evidence bundle into the attack category its indicators most strongly
    support (highest count of matching known indicators for that category).

    Args:
        indicators: list[str] of evidence tags collected during an investigation.
    Returns:
        str — the best-supported category name ("brute-force", "sql-injection", "malware",
        "phishing"), or "unknown" if no indicator matches any known category. Ties are broken
        by choosing the alphabetically first category among the tied leaders. See
        interface.md for the exact indicator-to-category mapping.
    """
    # TODO: implement per prompt.md
    raise NotImplementedError("implement solve() — see prompt.md")
```